

SJAA Ephemeris Bulletin

✱ May 2025

Galaxy Season

What's your favorite season? Spring? Summer? How about, Galaxy? For me, "Galaxy Season" is the best of them all. While perhaps a bit more conceptual than its traditional counterparts, Galaxy Season is the time of year, typically throughout the spring and summer in the northern hemisphere, when constellations rich in galaxies are best placed for nighttime observing.

Highlights include the Leo Triplet, M81, M82, the Whirlpool Galaxy, and this month's feature, the Sombrero Galaxy. The Sombrero is found in Virgo, which also hosts Markarian's Chain: an amazing stretch of galaxies that form a long chain celestial wonder set against a backdrop of stars and other distant galaxies.

May is also another month full of great SJAA events, including another Pinnacles Star Party on the 24th, and our highly acclaimed Telescope Workshop on the 18th. Don't miss out, and keep looking up!

Carl Svensson
Vice-President
Ephemeris Editor

Target of the Month - M104

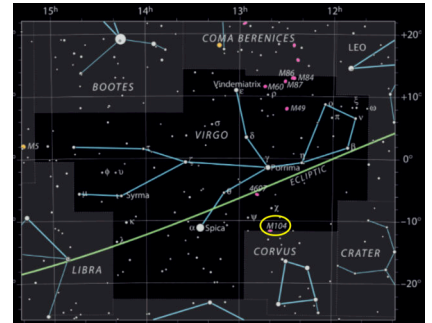
by Joe Fragola

Also known as the "Sombrero Galaxy," M104 was discovered by Charles Messier's colleague Pierre Méchain on May 11, 1781. Charles Messier made a handwritten note about M104 and added it to his personal list, but it was not officially included in the Messier Catalog until 1921, when the French astronomer, and author, Camille Flammarion found said list.

The nickname for M104 comes from the appearance of the central galactic bulge and the dust lane that crosses in front of it. The symmetrical dust ring around the bulge contains most of M104's hydrogen gas and dust. It is the primary site of starburst activity within the galaxy. Messier 104 also boasts a large population of globular clusters. Estimates range from 1,200 to 2,000 globular clusters. By contrast, our own Milky Way galaxy has only 150 known globular clusters.

Find the Sombrero Galaxy in the constellation Virgo. Look for an object about 8.0 magnitude with an apparent size of about 9' x 4'. Happy hunting!

Magnitude	8.0
Size	105 kly x 57 kly
Object Type	Spiral Galaxy
Constellation	Virgo
Distance	28-32 Mly
Age	10-13 billion years



Top: Virgo sky chart from theskylive.com. Bottom: M104 image from 4.3.2025 by Joe Fragola. Twenty minutes on Celestron Origin.

Volunteer Opportunities

There are many volunteer opportunities in SJAA! While we love having seasoned experts in our volunteer ranks, we happily welcome enthusiastic beginners, too. Please do not hesitate to reach out to the volunteer coordinator (volunteerchair@sjaa.net) to inquire about opportunities. Below are a few examples of programs that could use help:

Imaging SIG The SJAA Imaging SIG (Special Interest Group) welcomes members to give talks in our monthly imaging meetings on topics related to astro-imaging. World-class expertise not required! Example topics include: comet astrophotography, solar imaging, PixInsight skills, NINA tutorial, remote imaging, collimating telescopes, "my favorite astro gadgets", the science behind astrophotographs, "I love my mount/scope/software/...". Please don't be modest, we need you! For past talks see our YouTube channel ([@sj-astronomy7497](https://www.youtube.com/channel/UCsj-astronomy7497)). Please email imagingsig@sjaa.net if you're interested.

Loaner Program Our loaner program is looking for one to two more volunteers to help members check out gear and to demonstrate the set-up and usage of loaned items. The only requirement is an interest in astro gear and

Announcements

Tell us how you REALLY feel... SJAA kindly asks our members to take 10-15 minutes to fill out our new survey. Help SJAA grow in all the right ways by giving us your honest feedback. As we plan for our near-term and long-term success, your feedback is vital to help us serve the community as best we can. Please check it out at: <https://form.jotform.com/251049002029041>

availability on one Sunday per month. Email loaners@sjaa.net if you are interested.

SSP The School Star Party Program is looking for more regular volunteers. We provide fun and exciting observing opportunities for schools. The ideal volunteer should have a telescope, some basic astronomy knowledge, and enjoy inspiring people. Interested parties should be available for the events and can contact ssp@sjaa.net for more information.



SJAA May 2025

Sunday	Monday	Tuesday	Wednesday	Thursday	Friday	Saturday
				1  24%	2  34%	3  Astronomy Day Mars 2° S of Moon 45%
4 FixIt, Loaner Exchange 2:00PM Solar Sunday 2:00PM  Mars 0.4° N of M44 56%	5  Peak of Eta Aquariid Meteor Shower 66%	6  75%	7  83%	8  90%	9  Astro 101 (Online) 7:00PM 95%	10  Board Meeting 6:00PM Guest Speaker 8:00PM Spica 0.4° N of Moon 98%
11  98%	12  Full Moon 100%	13  Antares 0.3° N of Moon 100%	14  97%	15  93% Williamina Fleming's Birthday (1857)	16  87%	17  79% Starry Nights Star Party 9:15PM
18  70% Telescope Workshop 1:30PM	19  60%	20  49% Imaging SIG (Online) 7:30PM Last Quarter Moon	21  38%	22  27% Neptune 2° S of Moon Saturn 3° S of Moon David Levy's Birthday (1948)	23  17% Astro 101 8:00PM In Town Star Party 9:15PM Venus 4° S of Moon	24  9% Mendoza Ranch Stargazing 7:45PM Pinnacles Star Party 10:00PM
25  3%	26  0% Memorial Day New Moon	27  1%	28  5%	29  11%	30  20% Walter Scott Houston's Birthday (1912)	31  29% Martin Schwarzschild's Birthday (1912)
			Times and dates are subject to change. Please check sjaa.net and www.meetup.com/sj-astronomy for the latest updates. Meteor Shower Dark Sky Window			